

delivery personnel to even peep into these mysterious structures. “We don’t want our competition to know what is happening inside our dark store,” says Aadit Palicha, Co-founder & CEO of Zepto. “We have optimised to a point that within 76 seconds of an order being placed, the order is packed and made ready for pickup. So, the tech we use is a trade secret, and we wouldn’t want anybody to get wind of it. The SOP is to not let anybody in. There are tighter aisles, and SKUs of frequently ordered products are accessible.”

DARK DELIVERIES

Dark stores are typically 2,500-3,000 sq. ft in size, and are carved out of shuttered buildings or gone-out-of-business stores, and allow the companies not only to save costs, but also reach deep corners of cities and even semi-urban areas.

Due to their nature, it’s difficult to spot a dark store—it is not likely to

keep its front doors open for you to watch or waltz into. The only way to figure out that there’s a dark store in a locality is by spotting delivery people waiting around to pick up orders. For instance, we figured out where Zepto’s dark store was in Mumbai’s Lower Parel by spotting delivery staff milling around a location in their purple T-shirts and helmets. Similarly, you’ll spot the orange jerseys of Swiggy’s Instamart and the yellow jerseys of Zomato’s Blinkit.

How does a dark store function? After keenly observing the Zepto dark store and speaking with several industry insiders, we zeroed in on the following modus operandi: When a user places an order on Zepto, the system at the store showcases the list of items on a screen, and within two minutes a store staff packs it in a paper bag and places it in a pigeonhole, located near the entrance of the store. Meanwhile, a delivery partner who is closest to the store (or within less than a 1-km ra-

dius) gets a notification asking her/him to accept the delivery.

Upon accepting it, the delivery partner reaches the store in the next couple of minutes and gets a prompt about the rack number of the pigeonhole. She then scans the barcode of the rack, opens the paper bag to confirm the items, and then sets off for her destination. With the clock ticking, the delivery partner has about 8-10 minutes to make the delivery. The workflow at the two other companies is largely similar. Quite obviously, the most essential ingredient in this flow is speed.

THE BRIGHT SIDE

Speed, rather unparalleled acceleration in orders, is what the online grocery delivery business in India saw during the lockdowns induced by the Covid-19 pandemic. According to data analytics website Statista, the Indian online grocery market nearly tripled in size from ₹15,000 crore

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